some major historical differences. Africans formed a far greater proportion of Cuba's population, and they continued to arrive in large numbers during most of the nineteenth century. This presence meant that African languages, religions, and cultures remained much more alive in twentieth-century Cuba than in the United States.

In the United States, the independence movement was carried out by whites – many of them slaveholders – and the nation established in 1776 committed itself to maintaining the slave system. Not until almost a hundred years later were blacks granted citizenship. Even then, the country's white leadership was committed to a policy of territorial expansion and racial exclusion.

In Cuba, colonial rule lasted over a century longer, and slavery was understood as a part of the colonial system, firmly rejected by many leaders of the independence movement. "To be Cuban comes before being white, before being black, before being mulatto," white independence leader José Martí announced in an oft-repeated phrase. Independence would create a country "with all, and for the good of all."[6]

The Cuban War of Independence began in 1868 when plantation owner Carlos Manuel de Céspedes issued the "Grito de Yara," freed his slaves, and called upon them to join him in fighting for Cuba's independence. He was soon joined by Antonio Maceo, the "Bronze Titan" – the mixed-race son of a Venezuelan farmer and a free Afro-Cuban woman, Mariana Grajales. Together with José Martí these three formed the pantheon of Cuban independence leaders, highlighting for future generations the diversity that the movement represented. The Mayor of Havana officially named Grajales as "the mother of Cuba" in 1957. Each of these heroes of independence today has a Cuban airport bearing his or her name: Cuba's main international airport in Havana is named after José Martí (as are its National Library and other important institutions), while the airports in Santiago, and Guantánamo and Bayamo are named, respectively, after Maceo, Grajales, and de Céspedes.

National independence, then, and national identity, were associated with ideas of racial equality and racial unity in Cuba in a way very